CHECKLIST · FOR CLUBS, ACADEMIES, AND SPORTS BUSINESSES USING DATA

Is your data ready for AI?

Most AI problems in sports start with the data, not the model. Run through these three checks before you train a model, buy a tool, or trust a scouting or performance score.

1 · CLEAN Is the data accurate?

Garbage in, bad calls out

- [ ] **Keep an untouched copy of the raw data** and write down every change you make. You need to be able to undo a bad cleaning decision.
- [ ] **Remove duplicates before you split training and test data.** The same match logged twice in two systems makes test scores look "fake good."
- [ ] **Spot-check your labels by hand.** Coach ratings, "starter" tags, and highlight tags can be inconsistent. Check a sample before trusting them.
- [ ] **Don't throw out data just because it's unusual.** A different league, language, or stat format may be exactly the players the model needs to learn.

2 · FAIR Does it work for everyone it will judge?

Good on old data isn't proof

- [ ] **Ask what your labels really measure.** "Got recruited in the past" is not the same as "will succeed." Old decisions can carry old biases.
- [ ] **Check results by group, not just overall.** A model can be accurate overall and still miss smaller-school, international, or women's players.
- [ ] **Pilot it on real data from the new setting first.** A model built on D1 men's data has not been tested on NAIA, youth, or another country.
- [ ] **Watch for feedback loops.** Players a model overlooks never get chances, so they disappear from future data and the model never learns it was wrong.

3 · PROTECTED Is athlete data safe and governed?

Especially for minors

- [ ] **Collect only what you need,** and only for a stated purpose. Injury, wellness, and contact data for minors deserve extra care.
- [ ] **Before sharing data with another club, check that it's compatible.** Different tagging or testing methods can mislead a combined model.
- [ ] **Remember that "no names" isn't always anonymous.** Age, team, position, and dates can still point to one player.
- [ ] **Put it in writing:** who can use the data, for what, how long it's kept, and who's responsible if there's a breach.

Rule of thumb: trustworthy AI isn't one clever technique. It's clean data, fair testing, layered protection, and checking again after launch.

Dedupe before you split

Or your test results are inflated.

Slice your metrics

Overall accuracy hides who the model fails.

Keep monitoring

Evaluation isn't a one-time event.

Ralph Montero · Master's in AI, Indiana Wesleyan University
ralphmontero.github.io/AIML-500-Professional-Portfolio

Based on the "Data Challenge Scenarios" exercise, AIML-500.
General guidance, not legal advice.